

Covid-19 Institutional Contingency Plan

March 2021

**LOCKDOWN
LEVEL 1**



Cape Peninsula
University of Technology

#KeepCreatingYourFuture

creating futures

COVID-19



MASKS MANDATORY

**Any person not wearing
a mask will be denied
entry to CPUT
campuses, as per
government regulations.**

Call the National toll free COVID
Helpline if you have symptoms **0800 029 999**



Cape Peninsula
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Dear Staff and Students

The President of the Republic of South Africa announced on 28 February 2021 that the country would be returning to Lockdown Level 1 (LL1) under the National State of Disaster due to the eventual decline of the second wave of infections. The LL1 regulations were subsequently extended on 11 March 2021 until 15 April 2021. The second wave of infections has been an extremely testing time for the country, and indeed CPUT, due to the effects on South Africans celebrating the Festive Season and the discovery of a new South African variant of the virus known as 501Y.V2. Sadly, we lost five members of the CPUT community (staff and students) during the period 1 December 2020 to 31 January 2021, bringing the total number of casualties to ten.

However, the month of February 2021 has also, for the first time since the announcement of the National State of Disaster back in March 2020, signaled a season of hope. At the end of February 2021, AY2020 was officially completed. This is certainly a remarkable achievement, and I would be remiss if I didn't express my sincerest appreciation to all academic leaders, academic staff, support staff and students for achieving what many would have thought to be impossible given the challenges faced along the way. All indications are that this was achieved at a success rate that matches those achieved before the pandemic. At the same time, the world has seen the introduction of much anticipated Covid-19 vaccines; and on our own shores, we have seen the first vaccinations taking place, including the first group of CPUT frontline healthcare workers.

In starting AY2021 during March 2021, we have to acknowledge how far we have come, which counts for good experience in our academic project this year. This also coincides with the first year of our roadmap towards Vision 2030, and whilst there will be many challenges, I would dare to say that our experience thus far with Covid-19 has paved the way for many new ideas in online education and the building of the Smart University. It is evidence that we can indeed achieve what many thought would be impossible.

It remains a time of extreme caution. Our Covid-19 Health Cluster introduced various measures to bring the pandemic under control under LL3. Now is not a time to relax though, as this would only allow the virus to return. Therefore, the Health Cluster's approach has been

to accept the responsibility handed to them during a stepdown of lockdown levels to retain certain protocols in order to stabilise CPUT from the highs and lows of locking and unlocking various activities. We will have to be especially cautious of the anticipated third wave of infections, which may start as early as the Easter holiday season and reach a peak in early May 2021.

It remains our responsibility to ensure that our community conducts itself with the necessary restraint under the guidance of our own Covid-19 compliance team, and within the protocols and decision-making realms of the CPUT Covid-19 Command Centre and CPUT Covid-19 Health Cluster.

Please continue to wear your mask, sanitise and practice social distancing. It is mandatory, and we will remain extremely vigilant in ensuring all the members of our community obey these protocols.

Prof Chris Nhlapo

Vice-Chancellor & Principal

1 MANAGEMENT OF COVID-19 COMPLIANCE

1.1 Completion of AY2020

During December 2020/ January 2021, new infections flattened out at around 25 new infections per week. As indicated in previous plans, there were still some academic matters outstanding for AY2020 that needed to be closed out in January and February 2021. Through various measures introduced, both nationally in terms of LL3 restrictions, as well as at CPUT, we managed to bring this number down to around 0–1 new infections per week for the months of February and March 2021.

At the time of publication of this revised Contingency Plan, we were able to, based on all information available, declare all of CPUT's staff, students and facilities virus-free, with a recovery rate of 100%. This was the best possible position to be in with the return of the bulk of the CPUT community as from 15 March 2021, as part of the start to AY2021. Of course, once the CPUT community expands its presence on campuses, it is unrealistic to project that this unique situation would perpetuate.

The state of Covid-19 as at 31 January 2021 and the consequent current state as at 15 March 2021 is shown in table 1 below:

Week Ending	31 Jan 2021	15 Mar 2021
Staff	137	141
Students	149	150
Grand Total	286	291
Deaths	10	10
Recoveries	227	281
Recovery Rate Excl. Deaths	82%	100%
Hospitalisation: High Care	2	0
Hospitalisation: ICU	1	0

Table 1: Covid-19 infections at CPUT as at 31 January 2021 compared to 15 March 2021

These statistics show that our health management systems did a remarkable job in holding their line of defense during the conclusion of AY2020 in February 2021. In situations where Covid-19 positive cases were detected during assessments, the response processes of closing out these cases, ensuring contacts were identified, traced and isolated, as well as sanitising were relatively well entrenched, and lead to a swift response, even where mini-clusters were suspected.

1.2 Start of AY2021

As at 15 March 2021, CPUT and its community is officially virus free, something which enables us to focus on a rapid response approach in isolating any new cases that may be detected. This is the ideal platform for return planning, and has even allowed us to scientifically adjust some protocols for a limited time window to assist the academic community to kickstart its activities for AY2021. This is of particular importance for first time entering students coming into campus, as well as students returning to residences.

Our Covid-19 committee structure is working well, and through these, our DVC: Teaching & Learning, the Deans of Faculties, and the Dean of Students have plotted the return plan for AY2021 in March 2021, in consultation with the Compliance Officer.

Staff will receive communication from their line management regarding their duties on- or off-campus as needed, and students will receive communication from their respective faculties when they are invited back to campus.

Due to the low-risk status at the time of publishing this report, the Covid-19 Health Cluster, after a proper scientific assessment of the risk involved, resolved that the 10-day rule (which required any CPUT staff member or student who travelled across provincial or international borders to isolate for 10 days before entering campus) to be revised temporarily to 7 days until 31 March 2021, after which the original 10-day rule will again be practiced.

Under special conditions, the CPUT staff member or student may request permission to submit a negative result from a Covid-19 test undertaken in Cape Town or an adjacent municipality within this prescribed period to circumvent the revised 7-day rule.



2 ACADEMIC READINESS

2.1 Completion of AY2020

At the start of 2021, the pandemic continued to be a disruptive force in the Higher Education sector. Yet, despite the challenges, CPUT was considered at low risk of completing the academic year 2020 by the Minister of Higher Education, Dr Blade Nzimande. The pandemic has helped to realise that values espoused in the CPUT Vision 2030, of kindness, compassion and Ubuntu, through the resilient nature of administrators, academic staff and students, ensured the completion of AY2020.

As part of closing out AY2020, the performance of students during AY2020 were compared to the pass rates of 2018 and 2019. The provisional results indicate that despite the disruptions experienced in 2020, the interventions and efforts by staff and students are reflected in the pass rates achieved. Many valuable lessons and skills have been learnt which would be helpful to faculties in the future. These novel practices will serve to confer adaptability and responsiveness to the faculties, allowing a better response to future disruptions.

The results are shown in table 2 below.

FACULTY	2018	2019	2020
Faculty of Applied Sciences	78%	77%	79%
Faculty of Education	90%	92%	89%
Faculty of Business and Management Sciences	76%	77%	79%
Faculty Engineering and the Built Environment	70%	70%	75%
Faculty of Health and Wellness Sciences	93%	94%	85%**
Faculty of Informatics and Design	79%	81%	80%
Institutional Pass Rate	79%	81%	81.5%
Deregistration	2.8%	3.3%	3.2%

Table 2: Pass Rates

*** Some marks not yet available at the time of publication of this Contingency Plan*

2.2 Start of AY2021

The **Faculty of Applied Sciences** returning students commenced their AY2021 as from 1 February 2021 on a staggered basis, and by 15 February 2021 most students have returned, with the exception of first-year students. Since health and safety remains a priority, this period (before first-year students arrive) will be used to complete as many necessary contact sessions as possible (such as practicals, face-to-face presentations, essential consultations), for returning students. When first-year students report for the 2021 academic year, they will be prioritised for contact sessions. In order to better prepare the returning students, refresher courses of all essential orientation content will be made available, so that students (especially those in second year – first-year in 2020) can be suitably acclimatised to blended pedagogy and its expectations. Tutors, Retention Officers and Mentors have been selected from the returning students, and have been appointed early in order to provide support for returning students, and to prepare them for the arrival of the first-year cohort.

The **Faculty of Education** commenced the 2021 academic year with online teaching and learning for returning 2nd to 4th year BEd and postgraduate students. Face-to-face lectures have been adopted for the following programmes during the first term: PGCE FET and ADTTVT. Both these programmes are offered for the first time in 2021. The groups are fairly small and can easily be accommodated on campus while still adhering to the guidelines of social distancing. Classes commenced on 1 March 2021. During the course of 2021, the student numbers on campus will be limited to one year group of BEd students on campus at any given time. Different year groups will go out to schools for Teaching Practice (TP) for 8 to 10 weeks at a time, to reduce on-campus numbers. When a specific year group is not attending on-campus lectures, they will either be doing TP or attend online classes. The first group of students that will attend face-to-face classes is the first-years, as they are new to online learning and need to be supported right from the start. These classes will commence on 12 April 2021.

The **Faculty of Business and Management Sciences** commenced with AY2021 on 1 February 2021. All classes in the FBMS commenced via remote teaching and learning, as part of the multimodal model adopted by CPUT. As per the institutional calendar, first

year students commence classes on 15 March 2021. The institutional Implementation Action Plan AY2020 was adapted for the FBMS, and incorporates the institutional principles of remote teaching and learning, face-to-face teaching and learning, hard copy support (i.e. study packs and memory sticks) and assessments. Planning for AY2021 included detailed actions such as communication strategies to students and revising subject guides to clarify expectations and understanding of remote teaching and learning.

The **Faculty of Engineering and the Built Environment** commenced with multimodal delivery of the curriculum for returning students by 15 February 2021. The initial commencement of the curriculum is online. For semester 1 and term 1, the Faculty will be focusing on returning students for on-campus activities from 1 March to 31 March 2021. All departments identified the subjects from year 2 onwards (returning students) that require on-campus activities, and letters have been sent to those students to inform them of when they are expected to be on campus for those activities. The Faculty has prioritised programmes and subjects that require on-campus activities, such as practical sessions, laboratory work, and specialised software and equipment.

The **Faculty of Informatics and Design** will continue with online learning and see how the lockdown levels change before making adjustments to the teaching and learning arrangements.

The **Faculty of Health and Wellness Sciences** will, like the other faculties, have returning students back on campus before the first-year students. As a result, the period will be used to complete as many necessary contact sessions as possible, such as practical sessions, face-to-face presentations, essential consultations, etc. Refresher courses of all essential orientation content will be made available, so that students, and especially those in the second year (first-year in 2020) can be suitably acclimatised to blended pedagogy and its expectations. The multimodal approach will continue. Tutors, Retention Officers and Mentors will be selected from the returning students, and trained early in order to prepare them for the arrival of the first-year cohort.

Students from all faculties are reminded to await communication from their respective faculties regarding the dates for on-campus activities.

2.3 Registrations

Whilst late registrations are open for returning students, first-year final acceptances and registrations commenced soon after the official publication and download of the official 2020 NSC results at end February 2021. Although online assistance is available to all students, and students are encouraged not to report to campus, provision has been made to assist applicants and prospective students on-campus and to cater for those experiencing difficulties with online assistance, applications and registrations.

A first-year applicant and prospective student guideline pamphlet, available on the CPUT website, and translated into three languages, has been designed with the aim of preventing unnecessary reporting to campus for face-to-face assistance, but rather to conduct applications and registrations off-campus.

In addition, the CPUT website has also been updated with the guiding information and step-by-step procedures, with regular social media announcements.

The closing date for late applications for programmes with available spaces was extended until 26 March 2021 to cater for those having difficulties with applications, registrations and/or online assistance. Late registrations have been extended until 31 March 2021 for both returning and first-year undergraduate programmes. The closing date for Postgraduate Full Masters and Doctoral programmes was also extended until 19 March 2021.

2.4 Devices and Connectivity

Since Covid-19 is expected to be with us for most of 2021, students need to adapt to this “new normal”. Part of this adaptation is how students will access online learning content when they are either on- or off-campus in the new academic year (AY2021).

CTS has therefore developed a multi-faceted approach to deal with student online access.

- All students have access to Wi-Fi via the CPUT-Users or Eduroam SSID when on campus and in any of the CPUT owned residences.
- There are 160 Eduroam hotspots across South Africa, allowing all CPUT students access to the Internet via the Eduroam SSID. The link below lists where these hotspots can be found. (<https://www.eduroam.org/where/>)
- If a student is studying at home where there is Internet/ Wi-Fi access, that student is encouraged to use their home Internet/ Wi-Fi.
- Students are also encouraged to use the zero-rated websites (<http://klytho.cput.ac.za/zero-rated-sites>) and the zero-rated Student VPN Portal solution (<https://sop.cput.ac.za>) at no cost to the student.
- If, however, none of the above options are available to the student, CPUT will provide that student with data via an application process.

2.4.1 Student Data Allocation

Data will be allocated in two cycles in the month. The first cycle will be at the beginning of the month, and the second cycle will be mid-month. Applications for data generally close a week before the allocation date of that cycle to facilitate the timely distribution of the list to the various MNO's for loading on the cycle distribution date. The Student Data Application system is available on OPA.

2.4.2 Terms and Conditions

<https://opa.cput.ac.za/index.php/student-data-request-terms-and-conditions>

Students are encouraged to consult the FAQs developed, as this may answer many of the questions on the process.

2.4.3 Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

<https://opa.cput.ac.za/index.php/student-data-request-faq>

All queries relating to any of the approaches listed above, to aid students to access online learning material, must be addressed to the CTS Service Desk at ctsservicedesk@cput.ac.za or Tel. 021 959 6407.

CPUT has requested to be part of the NSFAS DIGITAL LEARNING DEVICE PROGRAMME. We therefore await the distribution of devices from NSFAS, which should occur in April 2021.

3 STUDENT READINESS

3.1 Return to Residences

In line with ensuring compliance with the regulations under LL1 within our residences, our Covid-19 protocols have been reviewed and updated to accommodate for this period. See below for more details.

3.2 Covid-19 Protocols

All our protocols are aligned with governmental guidelines on social distancing requirements and health and safety protocols, as prescribed by Higher Health, to ensure the Institution is well prepared for the return of students.

We again commit to giving students sufficient time to travel back from their respective provinces. All students will receive communication in this regard, and no student will be allowed back without such an invitation.

3.3 How to Report any Signs or Symptoms of Covid-19

As per CPUT Health protocols (all available on the CPUT website), the following conditions will apply:

- Students will be informed and educated on the procedures to follow if they experience any signs and symptoms of Covid-19.
- Students residing in campus residences are legally obliged to report their Covid-19 positive status to the Institution. CPUT established and maintains a central register. The HOD of Campus Health is the custodian of this register.
- Students in campus residences are to report their Covid-19 positive status via the respective Residence Coordinator, who will in turn notify the HOD Housing immediately. The HOD will inform the Safety, Health and Environmental Health Unit (SHE) on the prescribed Covid-19 Reporting Form, and the HOD of Campus Health.

The Covid-19 Reporting Form requires the following critical information:

✓	Student Name
✓	Student Number
✓	Faculty/Unit
✓	Department/Section
✓	Reported by
✓	Campus residence
✓	Contact number
✓	Case report (including contacts, where possible)
✓	Date referred to the Campus Health
✓	Other medical referral/attendance
✓	Tested: Yes/No and outcome:
✓	Any other information to report (if there is a co-morbidity Yes/No/Unknown)

3.4 Post-reporting procedure

- Contact tracing must begin immediately after a Covid-19 positive case is confirmed.
- All buildings, residential units and areas where a person found to be Covid-19 positive was present must be identified and will be closed for access until cleaned and disinfected by the Director of Property Services.
- Suspect; confirmed; and contact cases will all be dealt with according to National Protocol through quarantine, isolation and hospitalisation, as deemed appropriate.
- With the imminent return of students, we will continue educational drives on alerting students to the symptoms of Covid-19.

3.5 Wellness and Psychosocial Services

We are aware that Covid-19 has resulted in anxiety, stress and other challenges for our students. Student counselling services were available in previous lockdown levels, but as online services. Marketing of counselling services has been regular and intensified under LL3. We will continue to do so as our students return to University. Counselling staff is available on campus and through a call centre to assist students, whilst observing all health and safety protocols.

3.6 Communication Campaigns

Various communication campaigns, both online and through posters have been launched and will continue in order to ensure that students remain vigilant regarding the virus. Please note the exhibit below.



3.7 Residences

In line with social distancing requirements, only students who have permission to return to campus will be allowed to do so and return to campus residences.

- **Staff training:** We have been working hard to ensure that our staff is trained on the latest Covid-19 protocols, and that our students understand that we all have an active role to play in flattening the curve and keeping the virus off our campuses. Refresher training will be undertaken.
- **Signage in buildings:** All residences have the required Covid-19 signage and we will continue with our education drives to educate students on how they should comply with government health and safety regulations in residences and public areas.
- **Cloth masks:** Two masks will be provided to all students to ensure that proper Covid-19 protocols are followed.
- **Hand sanitisers for each student:** Upon arrival, students will be provided with hand-sanitisers.
- **Intensified cleaning protocols:** Residences are sanitised weekly. We will intensify cleaning procedures around touch-points throughout our buildings, with decontamination applied when and where appropriate.
- **Communal areas:** All social areas in our residences will have restricted access in relation to social distancing regulations.
- **Residence rules:** All returning residence students will be issued with our Covid-19 house rules, which aims to keep all students safe in our buildings.
- **Increased communication** to students, as in previous lockdown levels, will continue.

3.8 On Arrival Procedures

3.8.1 Screenings

- ✓ All students entering our university campuses will be screened using the HealthCheck app which will determine if they are low, medium or high risk for Covid-19. Students' temperature will also be taken.
- ✓ If detected to be medium or high risk, the student will proceed to the CPUT Covid-19 health facility for a full screening.

3.8.2 Distribution of PPEs

- ✓ Residence students will receive masks and hand sanitisers upon check-in at the residence, after screening.

3.8.3 Protocol on Visitation in Residences

These protocols have been developed to manage LL1 visitations within the residences of CPUT which includes owned, leased and accredited properties. The protocols extend to the management of visitors in residences and students who might want to undertake visits to their families. It is important to note that opening the economy does not lessen the risk of contracting Covid-19. However, this is the Government's decision to save lives and livelihoods, and it is not because it is completely safe to do so. For this reason, students are urged to exercise more caution and be more vigilant than ever before. It should further be noted that none of the precautionary measures have been removed or relaxed, in that protocols still remain in place, inter alia, the mandatory wearing of masks, adhering to physical distancing of 1.5 to 2 metres from another person, practicing respiratory hygiene, and the regular washing/ sanitising (with 60–70% alcohol-based sanitiser) of hands. These precautionary measures may most likely, be with us for quite a while, most certainly for the remainder of the year. Please do know that Management has a deep understanding of students' needs to socialise and to have regular interactions with friends and family.

However, CPUT will continue to monitor compliance to Covid-19 protocols as the third wave of the pandemic in South Africa is nearing. Your health must remain a top priority.

Importantly, it should be noted that the reintroduction of visitation in the residences is in line with the terms and conditions which all registered students should have accepted, wherein students commit to safe behaviour and that they will not participate in off-campus activities that are risky during this time, see link: <https://opa.cput.ac.za/index.php/student-travel-permit>

This decision is also in line with the roommate agreement which is applicable to students in sharing rooms.

VISITORS IN THE RESIDENCES

All Covid-19 health and safety protocols of sanitising, maintaining a 1.5 m physical distance, and wearing of masks must be adhered to.

- For senior students only: Visitors are permitted from 18h00 to 22h30 on a Wednesday night and 16h00 to 23h00 from Friday to Sunday. The rationale behind the limited visiting times is in line with encouraging respect for other students who might be busy with remote learning in their rooms.
- Only CPUT students are allowed to visit each other by producing a valid student card.
- No external visitors are allowed.
- First-year students will only be allowed other CPUT students as visitors from 29 March 2021 at the following times: from 18h00 to 21h00 on a Wednesday night and 16h00 to 21h00 from Friday to Sunday.
- A student in a single room is restricted to not more than two visitors at any point in time.
- A student in a double room is restricted to only one visitor at any point in time. When both students have visitors, this will result in a maximum of 4 people in the room.
- A student in a triple room is restricted to only one visitor at any point in time. There should be no more than 4 people in the room at any point in time. This means that if all 3 occupants are present in the room, only one of them can have a visitor. The visitation time needs to be shared.

- The student host must take full responsibility for their visitor(s).
- All visitors must be signed in by security, produce identification, and must be screened at the entrances of each residence.
- All visitors must be wearing their masks and observe the recommended social distance of 1.5 to 2 metres at all times.
- All visitors signed in agree to observe all the necessary rules and protocols of the residences whilst on the visit, including observing all health protocols.
- Prior to visitation times and once the visitors leave, students should clean and disinfect the surfaces (door handles, counter tops, light switches, amongst others) of the area where the visit took place.

STUDENTS VISITING FAMILY

- Students planning to stay out overnight, for the weekend or for a longer period need to notify the Residence Coordinator by completing an application form obtainable from the Residence Coordinator at least 3 days ahead of the planned visit/ departure, unless of course, it is an emergency.
- Submit the form to the Residence Coordinator via email and await written acknowledgement of the notification within 24 hours. Emergency cases will be prioritised, and the student would have to alert the Residence Coordinator of this.
- The student, upon return, will need to quarantine in their room and ensure, as far as possible, minimal contact with other students for 10 days.
- Students should be cognizant of any signs or symptoms related to Covid-19 that may develop on return from a visit/ time away from campus, and undertake to self-monitor, as well as report any dry cough, sore throat, loss of smell or taste, shortness of breath, fever, muscle aches/ pains, headache, extreme tiredness, diarrhea, nausea and/or vomiting to the campus clinic or your doctor.
- Students, whilst undertaking their weekend away visit, are urged to observe all the necessary health and safety rules and protocols.

- Students are encouraged to be wary of visiting the elderly by exercising social distancing and wearing masks, as they are particularly vulnerable and prone to contracting Covid-19. This same caution should be exercised when visiting any person with co-morbidities.
- The student is restricted to only one stay-away from residence per month. A stay-away visiting register will be kept in the Residence Coordinator's office.
- This information is essential for track and tracing in the event of a Covid-19 outbreak.
- If any student violates the above rules, the student's visiting rights will be revoked.

The Covid-19 Health Cluster reserves the right to withdraw this concession if at any point it is of the view that there are behavioural issues or the institutional rate of infection is on the rise.

3.8.4 Quarantine

The current quarantine residence for Covid-19 positive cases not absorbed into the Western Cape Covid-19 care facilities will remain in place.

3.9 Student agreements

All students returning to residences and campuses should sign an agreement that they will commit to safe behaviour and will not participate in off-campus activities that are risky during this time. There will be a complete ban on all social gatherings on all campuses:

3.9.1 Agreement (Terms & Conditions)

I..... (full name and surname)
with student number.....acknowledge the difficult time
our country is faced with due to the Covid-19 pandemic.

I fully understand that in order for this pandemic to be defeated I need to play a significant role in ensuring that I act in a responsible manner at all times by carefully considering all my actions and acting in line with all set health protocols by the government and those substituted by the Institution.

I agree and commit to the following:

- i. To safe and responsible behaviour
 - a. This includes wearing my face mask at all times when in public spaces on-campus and off-campus
 - b. Keeping a social distance of 1.5 m to 2 m apart from others
 - c. Washing and/ or sanitising my hands regularly
 - d. Practicing safe respiratory hygiene
 - e. Wherever possible, through opening of windows and doors, allowing for natural ventilation
 - f. Reporting any close contact with persons infected with Covid-19 and reporting symptoms that I might experience to the relevant authorities at the Campus Health or my private GP. (If you opt for the private GP, kindly note that it is compulsory for you to inform the Institution through Campus Health.)
 - g. I will not participate in any off-campus activities that are risky during this time; this includes not going to places that are crowded, necessitate close contact, or have poor ventilation
- ii. I understand and commit to respecting the institution's moratorium/ complete ban on any and all social gatherings at the Institution or outside in the name of the Institution.

- iii. I agree and commit to playing my part in the fight against Covid-19 by acting responsibly.
- iv. I agree and commit to adhere to the provisions of the Disaster Management Act and the regulations promulgated thereunder from time to time.

3.9.2 Proposed method of access

The agreement is made available electronically, and each student can access it by clicking the link below:

<https://opa.cput.ac.za/index.php/student-travel-permit>



4 STAFF READINESS

4.1 Staff management under LL1

In accordance with the relevant Covid-19 related regulations/ directives, in 2020 CPUT line managers were asked to categorise staff into one of two categories, namely “work from home” and “work from campus”. This was done to minimise the number of staff reporting to work on campus, thereby reducing the potential for workplace Covid-19 infections. The end of 2020 saw a dramatic increase in the number of Covid-19 infections (second wave) which resulted in Government increasing the lockdown level from 1 to 3. The second wave has now passed, and the number of new daily Covid-19 infections has decreased. On 28 February 2021, Government reduced the lockdown level back to 1. Whilst a number of restrictions were lifted under LL1, the risk of infection still remains high, and the University is still required to adhere to various Covid-19 related regulations and directives, as well as its Workplace Plan. A key aspect of CPUT’s Workplace Plan is the reduction of staff who are required to perform their duties from campus (where possible).

The 2021 academic year was scheduled to start on 15 March 2021. We have already seen an increase in the number of students on campus in preparation for the start of the academic year. Line managers are requested to once again look at the different categories of staff to determine which staff members can work from home and which staff members must work from campus. Managers should consider the following guidelines when considering which staff members will be required/ allowed to report to work on campus:

- **Academic staff** – The University has adopted a multimodal teaching and learning methodology which allows for a portion of lectures and interaction with students to be done remotely (online). Line managers should only authorise academic staff members to report to work on campus if the staff member is required to perform functions that can either not be performed at home (online) and/ or requires the staff member to interact with students in person on campus. Line managers are required to complete the schedule updating the category in which each staff member falls into (i.e. allowed to work from home or required to work from campus), as well as the measures they have put in place to ensure compliance with CPUT’s Workplace Plan.

- **Support staff** – The number of support staff required to perform their duties on campus may increase in March/ April 2021 to assist with the enrollment and administration of students for the 2021 academic year. Line managers have been requested to complete the schedule updating the category in which each staff member falls into (i.e. allowed to work from home or required to work from campus), as well as the measures they have put in place to ensure compliance with CPUT's Workplace Plan.

Staff members who are unsure whether they are required/ allowed to report to work on campus should immediately contact their line manager for clarity.

4.2 Staff protocols

Isolation protocol post interprovincial and/ or international travel

In the Newsflash of 8 January 2021, we communicated a 10-day isolation protocol for staff returning home post interprovincial and/ or international travel under LL3. Executive Management has agreed to reduce the isolation period from 10 days to 7 days until 31 March 2021, after which we will revert back to the original arrangement of 10 days. Staff members considering interprovincial and/ or international travel should factor this protocol into their scheduling to ensure that they comply with this protocol on return from their interprovincial and/ or international travel. Staff members are required to inform their line manager of their intention to travel interprovincially and/ or internationally before embarking on said travel.

For ease of reference, we restate the protocol (with the amended isolation period) for staff who have undertaken interprovincial and/ or international travel below:

Authorised to work from home

Where a staff member is authorised to work from home, the staff member (on return to the Western Cape):

- ✓ must continue to work from home (unless on approved leave),
- ✓ may not report to campus for a period of seven (7) consecutive days post the staff member returning to their home (in the Western Cape).
- ✓ must immediately notify their Line Manager should the staff member develop symptoms of Covid-19 during this period and follow the relevant CPUT protocol (as previously communicated).

Required to work on campus

Where a staff member is required to work on campus post their return to the Western Cape, the staff member must continue to report for work on campus except:

- ✓ where the staff member develops any of the symptoms of Covid-19. In such event the relevant CPUT protocols must be followed, including immediately informing their Line Manager of these symptoms (as previously communicated); or
- ✓ the staff member is on approved leave.

Line Managers of staff who are required to work from campus and have recently undertaken interprovincial and/ or international travel should implement additional precautionary measures to monitor the staff member for Covid-19 symptoms (i.e. increased frequency of temperature checks) for a period of seven (7) consecutive days post the staff member returning to their home (in the Western Cape).

Non-compliance with Covid-19 protocols and regulations

A number of reports have been received of staff (and students) not complying with Government Directions and CPUT's protocols (especially the wearing of masks and social distancing). This is of serious concern. All staff are reminded that failure to comply with ALL CPUT policies, protocols, and procedures (including those addressing Covid-19 requirements) is a form of misconduct, and will be dealt with in terms of the CPUT ER Policy. Under CPUT's ER Policy, repeated misconduct or single incident of serious misconduct may result in a sanction of dismissal being applied, post a properly constituted disciplinary hearing.

Staff are reminded that they have a duty to report any and all instances of non-compliance of CPUT policies, protocols, and procedures (including those addressing Covid-19 requirements) which they see or are aware of. Failure to report non-compliance is a form of misconduct, and will be dealt with under CPUT's ER Policy.

4.3 Workplace Acquired Covid-19 Leave Provision

4.3.1 Context

Queries have recently been received from staff relating to what leave is applicable where a staff member is required to quarantine due to exposure in the workplace of a person who has tested positive for Covid-19. Two scenarios are possible:

- The staff member does not test positive for Covid-19; or
- The staff member tests positive for Covid-19 (termed workplace acquired Covid-19)

The laws relating to this question are fairly extensive and provide employers with specific direction on what they should (and should not) do when a staff member has come into contact with a Covid-19 positive person in the workplace. To make it easier to understand, we will not quote the relevant sections of legislation, but will reference the sections and Acts as applicable.

4.3.2 CPUT Sick Leave offering versus legislative provisions

The law covering the minimum sick leave requirement an employer must provide an employee is covered in Section 22 of the Basic Conditions of Employment Act, Act 75 of 1997 (BCEA). For CPUT staff (who work a 5-day week), the minimum sick leave provision is 30 days in a 3-year cycle. These 30 days are technically referred to as STATUTORY SICK LEAVE.

Sick Leave given in addition to STATUTORY SICK LEAVE is classified as CONTRACTUAL SICK LEAVE. The table below provides a breakdown of the total sick leave (statutory plus contractual) a CPUT staff member is entitled to.

Please note: CPUT sick leave cycle is based on a fixed 3-year period. The current sick leave cycle commenced on 1 January 2019 and concludes on 31 December 2021.

Staff appointed within a sick leave cycle are credited with a pro rata portion of sick leave based on the remaining period of the CPUT sick leave cycle.

STATUTORY SICK LEAVE	Full pay	30 days per 3-year cycle
CONTRACTUAL SICK LEAVE	Full pay	60 days per 3-year cycle
CONTRACTUAL SICK LEAVE	Half pay	90 days per 3-year cycle

4.3.3 Consolidated directions on Occupational Health and Safety Measures in Certain Workplaces (OHS Directions)

The Department of Employment and Labour has published Directions. The latest version of the OHS Directions was published on 1 October 2020, Gazette number 43751. Three sections of this Direction have relevance to the question at hand.

1. Assessment of a staff member's exposure post contact with a Covid-19 positive person in the workplace

Section 6(5 to 7) requires an employer to undertake an assessment to establish whether the staff member's exposure carries a high or low risk of exposure of transmission between staff members. For CPUT staff the assessment is conducted by the Campus Clinic. The following then applies:

- **Low risk of exposure** – staff member can continue working (monitor for symptoms for 10 days)
- **High risk of exposure** – staff member must be placed under quarantine for 10 days (a shorter period can be applied for healthcare workers).

2. Leave to be applied when staff member is classified as “high risk of exposure” and is required to quarantine

Section 6(7)(c) read in conjunction with section 6(3)(b)(iii) requires an employer to place the staff member on **paid sick leave** for the duration of the quarantine period and where the staff member has exceeded their sick leave entitlement, assist the staff member to apply for the UIF Illness Benefit.

3. Reporting of a workplace acquired Covid-19

Section 6(3)(b)(5) requires an employer to make a submission (claim) to the Compensation Fund where there is evidence to suggest that a staff member contracted Covid-19 in the workplace. Generally, this would apply to a staff member who has been classified as “high risk of exposure” who then tests positive for Covid-19 in the quarantine period. In such cases, the employer may not utilise statutory sick leave for the quarantine period but may use contractual sick leave to cover the quarantine period.

4.3.4 Summary of Leave Provisions due to Workplace Acquired Covid-19

Please see Table 3 for diagrammatic representation of the processes to be followed and the leave to be applied.

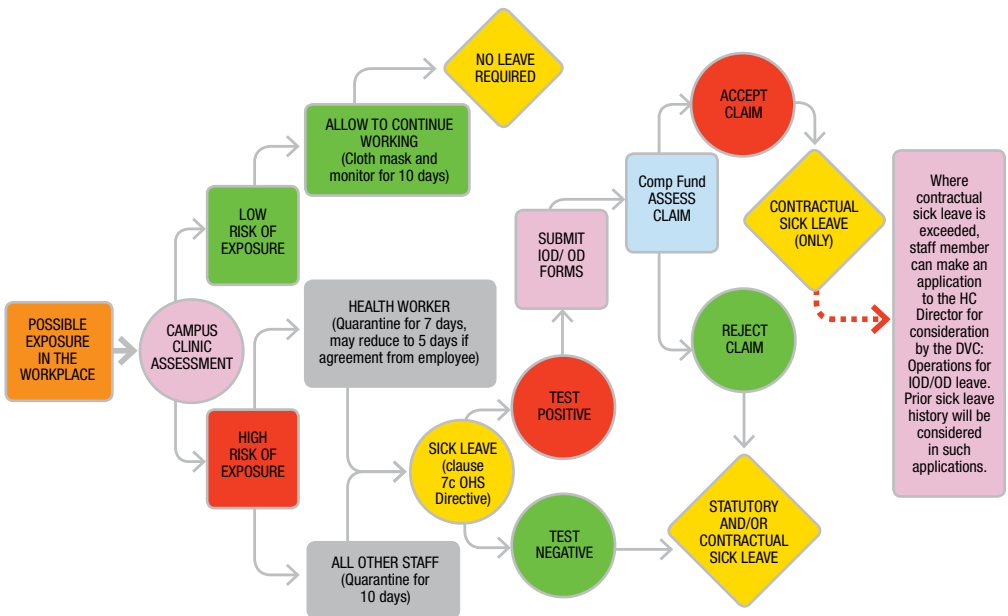


Table 3: Leave processes to be followed

4.3.5 Frequently asked questions

1. How will I know if I have been classified as being “high risk of exposure” in the workplace?

CPUT Campus Clinic uses the contact tracing information provided by a staff member who tests positive for Covid-19 to establish who had contact with the positive staff member, and conducts the assessment to categorise the exposure. The Department of Health has issued a guideline to assist with this assessment. Details of this was provided in the 24 July 2020 Newsflash.

2. What happens if I have no more sick leave available?

We understand there may be staff members who have exceeded their sick leave provisions. In such cases, the staff member can apply to the DVC: Operations, via the HC Director Operations and Services, for additional sick leave to be granted for the quarantine period. Only cases where the staff member is only entitled to statutory sick leave (e.g. due to recent appointment or working short-term fixed-term contract) or where the staff member has utilised their sick leave for a major event that required the staff member to be off due to illness or injury for an extended period (for example hospitalisation after a car accident, cancer treatment, etc.) will be considered. Where a staff member has exceeded their sick leave due to frequent short periods of absence, an application for additional sick leave will not be granted.

3. Does the law not say that where a staff member has been injured on duty or acquired a disease in the workplace, the employer may not utilise the staff member's sick leave?

Section 24 of the BCEA states that an employer may not utilise sick leave as provided for under section 22 of BCEA to cover any period of leave taken due to an injury at work or a disease acquired in the workplace, except in respect of any period during which no compensation is payable by the Compensation Fund. Section 22 relates specifically to STATUTORY SICK LEAVE. There is no legislative provision preventing an employer from utilising CONTRACTUAL SICK LEAVE to pay an employee over this period of leave.

5 CAMPUS READINESS

5.1 Preparing campus facilities

All office space, lecture theatres, laboratories, workshops and other facilities to be reopened have already been sanitised in collaboration with the line managers responsible for each faculty or division. Where the facility was not in use for more than 14 days, evidence has proven that the virus would not be alive.

Sanitising and cleaning is being undertaken before work commences in any facility to protect CPUT frontline staff members.

Property Services will avail a senior staff member to liaise with each line manager to conduct a walk-through of their facilities and agree on a checklist of items to be closed out to prepare the workplace before any staff or students enter these facilities.

5.2 Use of Technology

Portable thermal cameras have been implemented to do surveillance screening at high traffic and congested areas during the days at entrances. The mobile thermal cameras are portable and can be used to pin high fever individuals. The cameras can be used to perform screening in shuttles as well as high traffic residences. Surveillance screening does not replace the screening and recording of the staff and students, but is an additional screening method to minimize the risk.

We are also in the process of acquiring a card reader access control system that can be programmed to only allow people into any facility based on those cleared on the Covid-19 lists. The provisional implementation date for this device is 1 May 2021.

6 HEALTH MANAGEMENT SYSTEM READINESS

6.1 Screening and Case Management

Screening stations have again been placed in containerised solutions at all of the entrances to campuses and traffic is being relayed to these stations on a drive-through basis. Screening staff have also added a fast-lane process for those who use the Higher Health Screening App in order to minimise traffic congestion.

The current staff from Campus Health have been augmented by a nursing/ paramedic contractor to ensure sufficient qualified nursing staff overseeing all screening processes and responding to any emergency (including ambulance services if a Covid-19 positive case needs to be transported).

This staff will be expanded commensurate with the increase in infection numbers on campus.

6.2 PPEs and other Health Support Services

Please note that failure to wear a mask is an offence and will be dealt with according to CPUT's disciplinary codes.

Faculties, Departments and Units, can order their PPEs from Central Stores, through the normal ordering process by using their departmental budgets. The expected lead time will be two weeks. The account code for the listed PPEs is 45360.

Risk categories for PPEs need to be noted (departments must include the level of risk based on their orders, including total staff requiring the PPE):

6.2.1 HIGH RISK: Staff and students with co-morbidities; over the age of 60 years; and healthcare frontline staff:

- Surgical masks (healthcare frontline staff)
- KN95 masks (healthcare frontline staff)
- Cloth masks (safety specifications set out by Clothing and Textile Department)
- Face shield/ screen
- Hand sanitiser

6.2.2 MEDIUM RISK: Frontline staff, including Campus Protection Services and Cleaners who have face-to-face encounters:

- Cloth masks (safety specifications set out by Clothing and Textile Department)
- Face shield
- Hand sanitiser

6.2.3 LOW RISK: No co-morbidities and under the age of 60 years:

- Cloth masks (safety specifications set out by Clothing and Textile Department)
- Hand sanitiser

6.2.4 When can we order PPEs?

All staff, new students and returning students to be provided with one pocket hand sanitiser and two branded cloth masks.

Two new cloth masks and a sanitiser will be dispensed on a quarterly basis, starting February-March 2021, June, September 2021.

The full list is shown in Table 4 below.

ITEM	
N95 Facemasks	Sanitisers 100 ml, 200 ml, 5 litres, 50 litres
3 ply Disposable surgical masks	750 ml Spray bottles
3M Respirator masks Small	1 litre Bottles for foot pumps
3M Respirator masks Medium	Gloves Small
3M Respirator masks Large	Gloves Medium
Plastic visors (Face shields)	Gloves Large
Goggles	Cloth masks

Table 4: PPEs available

6.2.5 Contact details of Central Stores:

BELLVILLE CAMPUS

 tatanal@cput.ac.za
 peteniz@cput.ac.za
 021 959 6837 / 6852

DISTRICT SIX CAMPUS

 tidas@cput.ac.za
 zondib@cput.ac.za
 burnsm@cput.ac.za
 021 460 3076 / 3475 / 3537

6.3 Communication Strategy

Apart from the website and a major poster campaign (including a giant mask around the main administration building on Bellville Campus), the communication strategy was expanded to include an update from Management after the Covid-19 Command Centre meeting.

The following campaigns are now under way:

- Daily updating of dedicated Covid-19 webpages/ web information repository with all communiques, plans and protocols;
- Issuing institutional Newsflash email communiques on a weekly basis after Command Centre meetings;
- Social media support in the form of Covid-19 awareness and answering student/ prospective student queries for online registrations and application periods;
- Displays of CPUT Covid-19 dashboard on the CPUT digital signage (screens) system. This system is also used to present Covid-19 awareness materials;
- Production of Covid-19 awareness material (videos and graphics);
- Production of vaccination awareness material; and
- Production of desktop and wall calendars with a Covid-19 theme for distribution to all staff. The desktop calendar will be used to support SA government vaccine messaging objectives.

6.4 Vaccinations

CPUT is pleased to announce that the first group of 20 frontline healthcare workers from CPUT have received the Johnson & Johnson vaccine (called Janssen). This enables CPUT to have capacity to vaccinate our own community according to the sequencing announced by the National Department of Health. CPUT has created its own vaccination site which will soon be operational. The site will be at Sacco Hall on the Bellville Campus. We are very happy to announce that CPUT has been approved to become a community vaccination site for the region.

We are awaiting instructions from the National and Western Cape Departments of Health regarding the availability of vaccines, and the next group to be vaccinated.



One of the first frontline healthcare workers receiving a vaccine

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